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and races work fleetingly yet meaning-
 1950s British prejudice. Encountered
 the more visible on the other side of
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 to reflect — ranging from the multicultural
 1970s Rock Against Racism activities
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authority in *To Sir, With Love* and follow
 certainly appears dated in its attitudes
 removed from the more politically
 writing of Lammiman and Selvon. But
 Faithwaite's book, taught not by Ricky
 elia Dare, Gillian Blanchard, Seales,
 iative exchanges (always inclusive of
 ty of a transformative postcolonial
 Faithwaite's text. If Ricky cannot discern
 pupils, to sir, with love — then we at

Young, Single, Disillusioned: The Screen Heroine in 1960s British Cinema

MELANIE BELL
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Much has been written about the single young woman of the 1960s as a new
 ideal of socially and sexually liberated femininity, an image that was widely
 circulated through popular books and films such as *Billy Liar* (1959, 1963),
Darling (1965), and Helen Gurley Brown's *Sex and the Single Girl* (1962, 1964),
 the last exhorting the young modern woman not to tie herself down but to
 '[a]cquire men for your charm bracelet'.¹ Christine Keeler, the showgirl and
 former model caught up in the Profumo Affair of 1963, epitomized this image
 of female power and sexual liberation prevalent in the current cultural imagi-
 nary,² and by 1966 *Time* magazine confidently declared that 'the girls have
 become as [sexually] emancipated as the boys'.³ The fabric of the single-girl
 mythology was woven from innumerable texts ranging across sociology (*The
 Sexual Behaviour of Young People*, 1965), tabloid journalism (*Are Virgins
 Obsolete?*), public health literature ('Marrying with a Baby on the Way'), and
 the extension of contraceptive services to unmarried women in 1963.⁴ Sexual
 liberation, always more imagined than real for the majority of women, gave rise
 to the impulses of freedom and mobility that were widely expressed in cultural
 representation, particularly in popular film and television. Julie Christie, in

¹ Keith Waterhouse, *Billy Liar* (London: Michael Joseph, 1959), film version, dir. by John Schlesinger (Vic Film Productions, 1963); *Darling*, dir. by John Schlesinger (Vic Film Productions, 1965); Helen Gurley Brown, *Sex and the Single Girl* (London: Frederick Muller, 1963), film version, dir. by Richard Quine (Fernwood Productions, 1964). The quotation is from Brown, p. 113.
² See Lewis Morley's 1963 photograph of a naked Christine Keeler astride an Arne Jacobsen 'Butterfly' chair <<http://www.vam.ac.uk/content/articles/c/christine-keeler-photograph-a-modern-icon/>> [accessed 9 December 2011].
³ Piri Halasz, 'London: The Swinging City', *Time*, 15 April 1966, pp. 41.

⁴ Michael Schofield's *The Sexual Behaviour of Young People* (Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1968) suggested that middle-class girls linked sexual experience with notions of independence. For a discussion of public health and other literature, such as the articles mentioned, see Birmingham Feminist History Group, 'Feminism as Femininity in the Nineteen-Fifties?', *Feminist Review*, 3 (1979), 48–65 (p. 60). The first Brook Clinic, advising on sexual health, opened in 1963 in premises adjacent to the University of London, thereby linking, in the popular consciousness, sexual freedom with the educated woman. See Lesley A. Hall, *Sex, Gender and Social Change in Britain since 1880* (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2000), pp. 170–71.

Billy Liar and *Darling*, quickly became the embodiment of the new, youthful, liberated femininity unfettered by social and sexual convention, with the idea of mobility suggested by the 'active filming style' favoured by New Wave directors.⁵ *The Avengers*' Emma Peel (Diana Rigg), similarly, was television's first 'swinging heroine', described in the series' publicity as 'an emancipated, jet-age woman'.⁶ Fashion photography likewise went 'on location', shifting its models from the studio to the outdoor locations of urban streets, and constructing a modern, 'active' femininity through an emphasis on 'fluidity and movement'.⁷

While the free and liberated young woman was a commercially potent image for advertisers, filmmakers, and others, the figure represents a victory of image over reality. Many women (and men) did not experience sexual liberation in the way that it was popularly represented, nor did forms of sexual liberation equate to women's emancipation. As Patricia Waugh has argued, '[a]lthough sexual liberation may have begun in the early sixties, women's liberation would not get under way for a number of years'.⁸ What did circulate in the late fifties and sixties was an expression of women's dissatisfaction with the life options available to them. In the literary work of Sylvia Plath, Margaret Drabble, and Doris Lessing, alongside Betty Friedan's feminist sociocultural study *The Feminine Mystique* (1963), women recounted their experiences as wives, mothers, and lovers and how their sense of themselves as individuals was suffocated in these roles, accounts that have been understood as the antecedents to second-wave feminism.⁹ These themes of women's entrapment and the struggle for personal expression rarely found a voice in mainstream cinema, which, as I shall demonstrate, was inhospitable to expressions of femininity that questioned the dominant image of the mobile, free young woman. Nevertheless, there are some filmic accounts where women are given a narrative voice, and where dissatisfaction with the traps in which women are caught is expressed. In this essay I want to discuss three British films: *The World Ten Times Over*

⁵ John Schlesinger and Tony Richardson used lightweight lighting units, small cameras, and mobile recording units, which allowed them to shoot on location and capture a sense of mobility and contingency in their filming. See Laurie N. Ede, *British Film Design: A History* (London: I. B. Tauris, 2010), p. 95.

⁶ James Chapman, 'The Avengers: Television and Popular Culture during the "High Sixties"', in *Windows on the Sixties: Exploring Key Texts of Media and Culture*, ed. by Anthony Aldgate, J. Chapman, and Arthur Marwick (London: I. B. Tauris, 2000), pp. 37–69 (p. 54).

⁷ Hilary Radner, 'On the Move: Fashion Photography and the Single Girl in the 1960s', in *Fashion Cultures: Theories, Explorations and Analysis*, ed. by Stella Bruzzi and Pamela Church Gibson (London: Routledge, 2000), pp. 128–42 (p. 129).

⁸ Patricia Waugh, 'The Historical Context of Post-War British Literature', in *The Post-War British Literature Handbook*, ed. by Katherine Cockin and Jago Morrison (London: Continuum, 2010), pp. 35–56 (p. 47, emphasis original).

⁹ Ibid.

(1963), *The Beauty Jungle* (1964), and consciously feminist texts in the way they be, but they do provide a window on femininity that were offered to cinema. Joannou has argued, 'women-centred' the feminist critic as the essential but contentious contention that these films, in vocal to the burgeoning cultural expression eventually found a voice in second-wave

The first section of this essay discusses the emergence of these films, sketching out the shape and structure of the British film of women. In the second section I show how *World Ten Times Over* offer an alternative and then go on to place the figure of *Morning* in the context of Betty Friedan and other contemporary sociological studies

British Cinema: Male Fantasies/Female

British cinema of the 1960s was not a liberation of women. The sexually liberated of 'Swinging Britain', but she was frequently object, paraded across a range of cultural sexual male. Claims by critics such as a decade gave women far weightier roles, hopelessly optimistic.¹¹ We might compare the late heroine of the sociorealist *Yield to the New Wave's A Kind of Loving* 'bloody well put'; or the irreverent and comic mode — St Trinian's (1950–), *Gold Diggers for Value for Money* (1955) — with the *Peeping Tom* (1960). Even *Darling* such a shallow heroine, who is only Christie's star image. Explanations for culture are found in the complex interproduction and censorship that was taking where discourses concerning the sexual circulating.

¹⁰ Quoted in Clare Hanson, *Hysterical Fictions* (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2000), p. 2.

¹¹ Robert Murphy, *Sixties British Cinema* (London: I. B. Tauris, 2000), p. 1.

(1963), *The Beauty Jungle* (1964), and *Four in the Morning* (1965). These are not consciously feminist texts in the way that Plaths or Lessings might be said to be, but they do provide a window on to some of the alternative expressions of femininity that were offered to cinema audiences in the 1960s. As Maroula Joannou has argued, 'women-centred texts [...] must always be of interest to the feminist critic as the essential building blocks of feminist change'.¹⁰ It is my contention that these films, in vocalizing women's lack of mobility, contribute to the burgeoning cultural expressions of dissatisfaction with women's roles that eventually found a voice in second-wave feminism.

The first section of this essay discusses the industrial context to the emergence of these films, sketching out the ways in which important changes to the shape and structure of the British film industry impacted on the representation of women. In the second section I shall suggest how *The Beauty Jungle* and *The World Ten Times Over* offer an alternative picture of the young single woman, and then go on to place the figure of the trapped housewife in *Four in the Morning* in the context of Betty Friedan's *The Feminine Mystique* (1963) and other contemporary sociological studies.

British Cinema: Male Fantasies/Female Realities

British cinema of the 1960s was not particularly innovative in its representations of women. The sexually liberated young woman was central to the myth of 'Swinging Britain', but she was frequently reduced to nothing more than a sex object, paraded across a range of cultural texts for the pleasures of the heterosexual male. Claims by critics such as Robert Murphy that the cinema of the decade gave women far weightier roles than they had enjoyed in the fifties seem hopelessly optimistic.¹¹ We might compare the agentic and emotionally articulated heroine of the sociorealist *Yield to the Night* (1956) to the dim-witted Ingrid in the New Wave's *A Kind of Loving* (1962), who is told to 'live where she's bloody well put'; or the irreverent and hubristic heroines who prospered in the comic mode — St Trinians (1950–), *Genevieve* (1953), *Simon and Laura* (1955), *Value for Money* (1955) — with the deeply misogynistic *The Knack* (1965) or *Peeping Tom* (1960). Even *Darling* succeeds in creating a vacuous and intellectually shallow heroine, who is only partially rescued by the force of Julie Christie's star image. Explanations for this gender conservatism in sixties film culture are found in the complex interplay between changing modes of film production and censorship that was taking place within a specific social context where discourses concerning the sexuality of the young woman were repeatedly circulating.

¹⁰ Quoted in Clare Hanson, *Hysterical Fictions: The 'Woman's Novel' in the Twentieth-Century* (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, 2000), p. 2.
¹¹ Robert Murphy, *Sixties British Cinema* (London: British Film Institute, 1992), p. 33.

embodiment of the new, youthful, and sexual convention, with the idea of 'New Wave' style favoured by *Young Rigg*, similarly, was television's publicity as 'an emancipated, jet-set' went 'on location', shifting its locations of urban streets, and through an emphasis on 'fluidity and

man was a commercially potent image the figure represents a victory of image not experience sexual liberation in I, nor did forms of sexual liberation Patricia Waugh has argued, '[a]lthough early sixties, women's liberation would What did circulate in the late fifties dissatisfaction with the life options Sylvia Plath, Margaret Drabble, and feminist sociocultural study *The* mounted their experiences as wives, of themselves as individuals was sufficient understood as the antecedents to women's entrapment and the struggle in mainstream cinema, which, as I expressions of femininity that questioned, free young woman. Nevertheless, men are given a narrative voice, and each women are caught is expressed. In films: *The World Ten Times Over*

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 urts, ed. by Stella Bruzzi and Pamela Church
 in *The Post-War* (London: Continuum,

The British film industry faced a number of challenges in the 1960s. In the face of competition from television, audience numbers continued to fall, putting considerable economic pressure on studios to capture a share of a shrinking market. Rank, one of the major studios, increasingly withdrew from direct production and instead offered distribution deals to independent producers, some of whom were entrepreneurially minded and grasped the creative nettle.¹² Within this context some important independents emerged and prospered: Independent Artists (*This Sporting Life* (1963)); Anglo-Amalgamated, supporting the producer-director team of Joseph Janni and John Schlesinger (*A Kind of Loving*, *Billy Liar*, *Darling*); and Woodfall Films, formed in 1958 by John Osborne, Tony Richardson, and Harry Saltzman (*Look Back in Anger* (1959), *Saturday Night and Sunday Morning* (1960), *Tom Jones* (1963), *Girl with Green Eyes* (1964), and *The Knack*). As John Hill argues, 'it was the independent production companies who were increasingly well placed and most inclined to innovate', developing new projects and themes for the screen.¹³

The scope for creative autonomy and innovation dovetailed with the other major development of the decade: the increasingly liberal regime instigated by the British Board of Film Censors (BBFC) under the leadership of John Trevelyan. Trevelyan's support for *Room at the Top* (1959) opened up opportunities for filmmakers to engage with more 'adult' fare, with 'serious' and 'sincere' films, preferably with a literary 'quality' pedigree, supported by the BBFC, who were keen to shift the X-certificate away from its connotations of (s)exploitation.¹⁴ As Sue Harper has argued, however, '[t]he new freedoms temporarily blinded some film-makers to anything but sexual action', which did not bode well for female representation, a situation compounded by established women writers and directors either moving into television or leaving the profession entirely.¹⁵ The commercially successful Bond franchise, for example, offered actresses the role of sexual playmate, while Hammer horror drew such a sharp divide between sacred and profane women that little room remained for complexity or ambiguity in women's characterization.¹⁶ It did not follow, therefore, that the increased scope for entrepreneurialism or liberalization from censorship constraints led to any degree of radicalism in sexual politics.¹⁷ Little narrative space was devoted to female protagonists in whom the complexities of

the emerging new social and sexual perspective. For sure, the image of the female became a mainstay of cinema, but in the fantasy of sexual availability rather than in respect, her narrative function was the masculinity that dominated cinematic representation.

Given the new shape and structure of the industry, what new representations emerge? What gaps or interstices in patriarchal images could slip? Two possibilities emerge. The first is the literary/theatrical adaptation, many of whom were in the hands of O'Brien, Penelope Mortimer, Margot Forster, Shelagh Delaney, Ann Jellicoe, and others. The second is the screen in the 1960s that made it possible to debate about women, femininity, and the popular. *The Country Girls* (1960), for example, is at the centre of a *Bildungsroman* narrative of heterosexual love and female adaptation. It adapted the novel for the screen in 1960 and it enjoyed critical and commercial success. Redgrave playing the friends.¹⁸ The film appeared across a range of texts in the 1960s. *L-Shaped Room* (1960), *The Millstone* (1961). Philips has persuasively argued, as 'the social expectations of femininity'.²⁰ The film had a pre-sold audience, which would have been a fare for film producers, and the fact that the BBFC's active support for 'adult' quality was why these more innovative representations appeared on cinema screens.

¹⁸ For a discussion of the figure's shift towards the 1960s British Cinema: The Development of the Screen Heroine, 2nd edn (London: British Film Institute, 1986), p. 48.

¹⁹ *Girl with Green Eyes*, dir. by Desmond Dwyer, producer Tony Richardson. The casting built on the success of *A Taste of Honey* (1961) to create in O'Brien the 'artless' heroine.

²⁰ Deborah Philips, *Women's Fiction, 1945-1965* (London: Routledge, 2006), p. 38. Delaney's play *A Taste of Honey* (1961), Reid Banks's *The L-Shaped Room*, as a film *A Touch of Love* for the film version of 1969.

¹² See Sue Harper, *Women in British Cinema: Mad, Bad and Dangerous to Know* (London: Continuum, 2000), pp. 103-06.

¹³ John Hill, *Sex, Class and Realism: British Cinema, 1956-1963* (London: British Film Institute, 1986), p. 48.

¹⁴ Anthony Aldgate and Jeffrey Richards, *Best of British: Cinema and Society from 1930 to the Present* (London: I. B. Tauris, 1999), p. 195.

¹⁵ Harper, *Women in British Cinema*, p. 102.

¹⁶ *Ibid.*, p. 115.

¹⁷ *Ibid.*, p. 108.

the emerging new social and sexual freedoms could be explored from a female perspective. For sure, the image of the single, liberated young woman rapidly became a mainstay of cinema, but in ways that constructed the figure as a male fantasy of sexual availability rather than a female fantasy of control; in this respect, her narrative function was to contribute to the debates about masculinity that dominated cinematic representation in the sixties.¹⁸

Given the new shape and structure of the film industry, did filmmakers produce only conservative images of women or did any more radical representations emerge? What gaps or interstices were there through which non-patriarchal images could slip? Two areas present themselves for analysis. The first is the literary/theatrical adaptations from women novelists and playwrights, many of whom were in the early stages of their creative careers. Edna O'Brien, Penelope Mortimer, Margaret Drabble, Lynne Reid Banks, Margaret Forster, Shelagh Delaney, Ann Jellicoe, and Nell Dunn all had work adapted for the screen in the 1960s that made important interventions in contemporary debates about women, femininity, and personal freedom. Edna O'Brien's popular *The Country Girls* (1960), for example, places the young female heroine at the centre of a *Bildungsroman* narrative that tests the possibilities and boundaries of heterosexual love and female friendship in southern Ireland. O'Brien adapted the novel for the screen in 1964 (retitled *Girl with Green Eyes*), where it enjoyed critical and commercial success, with Rita Tushingham and Lynn Redgrave playing the friends.¹⁹ The figure of the young single mother appeared across a range of texts in the 1960s — *A Taste of Honey* (1958), *The L-Shaped Room* (1960), *The Millstone* (1964) — and functioned, as Deborah Phillips has persuasively argued, as a focus for discussions of contemporary social expectations of femininity.²⁰ The popular success of these texts created a pre-sold audience, which would have made them commercially attractive fare for film producers, and the fact that they also readily connected with the BBFC's active support for 'adult' quality fare provides some explanation as to why these more innovative representations of women found their way on to cinema screens.

¹⁸ For a discussion of the figure's shift towards male fantasy see Christine Gergahy, 'Women and 60s British Cinema: The Development of the "Darling" Girl', in *The British Cinema Book*, ed. by Robert Murphy, 2nd edn (London: British Film Institute, 2001), pp. 101–07 (p. 105).

¹⁹ *Girl with Green Eyes*, dir. by Desmond Davis (Woodfall Film Productions, 1964), executive producer Tony Richardson. The casting built on Tushingham's gawky, unconventional image from *A Taste of Honey* (1961) to create in O'Brien's central character, Kate, a direct, truthful, and 'artless' heroine.

²⁰ Deborah Phillips, *Women's Fiction, 1945–2005: Writing Romance* (London: Continuum, 2006), p. 38. Delaney's play *A Taste of Honey* (first performed in 1958) was produced as a film in 1961, Reid Banks's *The L-Shaped Room*, as a film in 1962, and Drabble's *The Millstone* was retitled *A Touch of Love* for the film version of 1969.

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of British: Cinema and Society from 1930 to the

The second area where more complex representations are found is less easy to categorize but emerges in the work of a number of film practitioners who took advantage of the new creative freedoms to direct their own original screenplays. Anthony Simmons (*Four in the Morning*) was a documentary filmmaker with some experience in low-budget feature film production but who did not connect with either Free Cinema or its subsequent iteration, the British New Wave. Val Guest (*The Beauty Jungle*) and Wolf Rilla (*The World Ten Times Over*) had over thirty years' experience in the British film industry between them, working their way up through the ranks of the old studio system and learning their craft through genre production. None of these men fits easily into existing explanatory models of 1960s British cinema. They are not New Wave directors, nor did they direct 'Swinging London' films or join the ranks of auteur directors like Ken Russell, Joseph Losey, or Lindsay Anderson. Nevertheless, or perhaps because of this, they produced films that engaged thoughtfully with the emerging new sexual politics and gave a sympathetic narrative voice to their female protagonists. Released in the same period as texts now widely considered emblematic of the 'new woman' of the 1960s (*Billy Liar*, *Girl with Green Eyes*, *Darling*, 1963–65) and now recently issued on DVD, these films enable researchers to supplement canonical texts with analyses of less familiar elements of sixties film culture. The fact that these films collectively address a wide variety of audiences and tastes — from the mainstream appeal of Guest's glossy, big-budget production to the niche market for Simmons's docudrama — points to their potential to broaden our understanding of the cultural texture of the period in suggestive ways.²¹

Struggling for Mobility

The Beauty Jungle (1964) was produced, directed, and co-written by Val Guest, a British filmmaker with an established track record in genre production and a good sense of public taste.²² A mature and confident director, the period between 1958 and 1964 was a time of relative risk-taking for Guest when he made the conscious decision to 'stop "playing safe" and take a few chances'.²³ This risk-taking extended to his representation of women, and in films like *The Day the Earth Caught Fire* (1961) and *80,000 Suspects* (1963) Guest carefully

²¹ Anthony Simmons's *Four in the Morning* has been released as part of Odeon's 'Best of British' Collection (2008), while Optimum released Wolf Rilla's *The World Ten Times Over* on their 'Classic' label (2010). Releases of Val Guest's work have focused on his well-known science-fiction output (*Quatermass*, *The Day the Earth Caught Fire*) and Hammer horror (*The Abominable Snowman*), suggesting that the, as yet, unreleased *The Beauty Jungle* does not fit readily into existing critical understandings of Guest's oeuvre.

²² Brian McFarlane, *The Encyclopedia of British Film* (London: Methuen, 2003), p. 275.

²³ Val Guest (1960), cited in Christine Geraghty, '80,000 Suspects', in *The Cinema of Britain and Ireland*, ed. by Brian McFarlane (London: Wallflower, 2005) pp. 135–45 (p. 135).

integrated female desire and autonomy into a global disaster and epidemic outbreak problem ethos with subplots of romantic style of realism' extended to an emotive *80,000 Suspects*, for example, a doctor's outbreak while their marriage disintegrates through communication. The woman's reflection on 'a wife won't do?') critique the choice of conventional gender roles, in their words. Christine Geraghty's comment that 'these films that "look back at the ethos and the reality which is beginning to feel like the end of an era" summation and captures the feeling of a desire for "something more" out of life' (*Jungle*, in which the concerns of the film are the main narrative).

The film was made by Guest under the auspices of funding for what is a glossy, attractive production with locations ranging from Bristol and Venice to Cannes. The film's A-certificate met Rank's family fare, but the strength and complexity of the film significantly from Rank's tradition of 'B' films), suggesting that Guest exercised independence in the conceptualization and execution. It is a young Bristol secretary, Shirley (played by entering a local beauty contest by an actress (Hendry). After Don's management becomes quickly outstrip his and she becomes involved in the international circuit, prepared to sleep with anyone placing. Eventually outmanoeuvred by a glamorous 'Miss Globe' competition, she realizes that she is little more than the 'tatty little thing'.

The film dramatizes the opportunity for a woman presents Shirley's single-minded and obsessive narrative space is given to the stultifying personal life, presenting the character in a sighted and sympathetic manner. Her fate

²⁴ I. Q. Hunter, 'The Day the Earth Caught Fire', in I. Q. Hunter (London: Routledge, 1999), pp. 99–100.

²⁵ Geraghty, '80,000 Suspects', p. 135.

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Film (London: Methuen, 2003), p. 275.
wer, 2005) pp. 135–45 (p. 135).

integrated female desire and autonomy into the main narratives of, respectively, global disaster and epidemic outbreak. Skilled at fusing a documentary/social problem ethos with subplots of romantic melodrama, Guest's *cinéma vérité* style of realism' extended to an emotional truthfulness in sexual politics.²⁴ In 80,000 Suspects, for example, a doctor and nurse work to contain a smallpox outbreak while their marriage disintegrates through infidelities and a lack of communication. The woman's reflections on the role of the 'perfect wife' (a wife won't do?) critique the choices available to women and suggest that conventional gender roles, in their current incarnation, are unsustainable. Christine Geraghty's comment that Guest in this period made a number of films that 'look back at the ethos and assumptions of the 1950s with a sensibility which is beginning to feel like that of the 1960s' is a particularly astute summation and captures the feeling of transition in his work.²⁵ The woman's desire for 'something more' out of life finds its fullest expression in *The Beauty Jungle*, in which the concerns of the female protagonist move from subplot to the main narrative.

The film was made by Guest under the aegis of Rank, which provided the funding for what is a glossy, attractive-looking film shot in Cinemascope with locations ranging from Bristol and Weston-super-Mare to Monte Carlo and Cannes. The film's A-certificate met Rank's increasingly outdated preference for family fare, but the strength and complexity of the central female role departs significantly from Rank's tradition of insipid heroines (see the 1950s *Doctor* films), suggesting that Guest exercised a considerable degree of creative independence in the conceptualization and delivery of the project. The protagonist is a young Bristol secretary, Shirley Freeman (Janette Scott), talked into entering a local beauty contest by an ambitious reporter, Don Mackenzie (Ian Hendry). After Don's management brings her early success, her ambitions quickly outstrip his and she becomes intensely competitive on the national then international circuit, prepared to sleep with competition judges to ensure first placing. Eventually outmanoeuvred by a more experienced rival in the prestigious 'Miss Globe' competition, she returns disillusioned to England, fearing that she is little more than the 'tatty little slut' that Don has labelled her.

The film dramatizes the opportunities available to 'ordinary girls' and presents Shirley's single-minded and naked ambition as entirely reasonable. Narrative space is given to the stultifying routines of Shirley's home, work, and personal life, presenting the character's actions and motivations in a clear-sighted and sympathetic manner. Her father is an accountant, her mother sings

²⁴ I. Q. Hunter, 'The Day the Earth Caught Fire', in *British Science Fiction Cinema*, ed. by I. Q. Hunter (London: Routledge, 1999), pp. 99–112 (p. 100).
²⁵ Geraghty, 80,000 Suspects, p. 135.

in the local Methodist choir, the family live in a respectable Bristol townhouse, and Shirley describes herself as 'an ordinary happy little typist'. Her stolid, unimaginative fiancé Harry, a junior accountant, constantly checks his watch ('you're seven minutes late'), and his idea of a Saturday night date, 'a quick drink at the Ostrich and dinner at the brasserie', clearly bores Shirley to tears ('ah yes, the good old brasserie . . . we haven't been there for a week'). Shirley's life is inescapably sliding towards marriage and life in the suburbs. After abandoning her date with Harry, a montage sequence of advertising billboards suggests the options available to women: 'Butlin's Holiday Camp Queen Contest!', which promises a first prize of £50, or 'The Royal Air Force Needs Women!', which offers respectability and a dull uniform. A cosmetics poster promising she will be 'Eminently Kissable' clinches the deal and Shirley opts for glamour over outmoded notions of duty.

Transformation is central to the film, and the idea of the female protagonist being caught between two worlds is signalled by two key aspects of the *mise en scène*: domestic locations and costumes, which both point to a society in transition. Shirley's row with Harry takes place against a backdrop of the Bristol docks, where burnt-out pre-war cars and abandoned warehouses take their place alongside the emerging new 1960s office blocks, all captured with Guest's *cinéma vérité* realist style.²⁶ The film opens on the beach at Weston-super-Mare, the traditional seaside setting of donkeys and deckchairs being disrupted by a bikini-clad Shirley and her girlfriends sprinting along the sands — the image of mobile, youthful femininity. The key visual signifier of Shirley's transformation from ordinary typist to beauty queen is effected through costume. In the opening scenes Shirley's cream-coloured, knee-length full skirts and medium-high heels place her as a 'skirt and sweater' girl, clothed in the accepted outfit of the respectable middle-class office girl of the late 1950s and early 1960s.²⁷ As the narrative progresses, Shirley's growing confidence and pleasure in her new life are expressed visually through her increasingly stylish outfits. When she arrives in Monte Carlo for her first international competition, her respectable office attire has been replaced by a smartly tailored suit in candy pink, the skirt's hem-length just above the knee and the tighter fit across the buttocks now denoting the character's increasing power and autonomy. Through a series of dinner dates and rehearsals, she showcases an enviable wardrobe of day, cocktail, and evening gowns in a dazzling array of colours: shimmering gold, bronzed orange, and cobalt blue. As Rachel Moseley has observed, the more

²⁶ This sequence echoes Julie Christie's earlier walk along a Bradford high street in *Billy Liar*, where bomb sites are cleared to make way for new supermarkets.

²⁷ For oral histories of women office workers in this period see Rachel Moseley, *Growing Up with Audrey Hepburn* (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 2002), pp. 150–51.

shocking, vibrant, and bold colours of that marked a sharp break with the past. Designed by Beatrice Dawson, a costume designer with experience at working with the expressive, the main signifying feature of Shirley's transformation is the more modern femininity that differs from the social and behavioural codes, of the past. The transformation effected through the film is a 'basic cultural trope which feeds into the narrative' that would have been easily recognizable to the audience's reading competencies.³⁰

The narrative suggests, however, that Shirley's transformation is not complete, and the plot ultimately works to contain her heroine: in the closing scenes she appears to be settling into her new life. The endings are common in popular genre films, where deviant femininity in the final reel. But the extravagant costuming work also serves to contain the morality. Further, Guest's script has a concern with the sexual politics that cannot readily be seen. Shirley's fiancé are presented as hypocrites. He is an immoral, yet pastes her press cuttings of her successful, while her fiancé wants her to be his proprietary gaze only. The question of the ambitious-minded young women who have been raised but remains unanswered is that of a free young woman of the sixties who is free of family and fiancé and is free to sleep with whom she pleases. The power still lies with the competition for the marketing deals. In this respect the film does not necessarily liberate women, but this is a necessary autonomy than a laying bare of the choices. That the film closes with Shirley as a beauty queen circuit points to a sense of stasis. Shirley's identity has yet to be fully imagined.

²⁸ Rachel Moseley, 'Respectability Sewn Up: The Sixties', *European Journal of Cultural Studies*, 4 (1999), 1–15.

²⁹ Beatrice Dawson's costumes are supplemented by the costumes of London, ensuring the tastes of female consumers are achievable to the aspirational.

³⁰ Moseley, *Growing Up with Audrey Hepburn*.

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walk along a Bradford high street in *Billy Liar*, in this period see Rachel Moseley, *Growing Up* University Press, 2002), pp. 150–51.

shocking, vibrant, and bold colours of the 1960s signified a 'modern' femininity that marked a sharp break with the 'pretty' feminine tones of the 1950s.²⁸ Designed by Beatrice Dawson, a costume designer with creative flair and experience at working with the expressive potential of colour, the costumes are the main signifying feature of Shirley's transformation from ordinariness to a more modern femininity that differentiates itself from the sartorial norms, and the social and behavioural codes, of the previous generation.²⁹ This narrative of transformation effected through the 'make-over' is, as Moseley has argued, a 'basic cultural trope which feeds into feminine culture in endless ways' and would have been easily recognizable to an audience equipped with feminine reading competencies.³⁰

The narrative suggests, however, that Shirley's transformation is unsustainable, and the plot ultimately works towards punishing or containing the heroine: in the closing scenes she appears to suffer a breakdown. Such moral endings are common in popular genre cinema, which typically neutralizes deviant femininity in the final reel. But the visual pleasures afforded viewers by the extravagant costuming work against the ending and its conservative morality. Further, Guests script has made some uncomfortable observations of sexual politics that cannot readily be dismissed. Both Shirley's father and fiancé are presented as hypocrites. Her father initially condemns her actions as immoral, yet pastes her press cuttings in a scrapbook after she becomes successful, while her fiancé wants her to save her exhibitionist tendencies for his proprietary gaze only. The question of what sustainable outlets there are for ambitious-minded young women who eschew the traditional route of marriage has been raised but remains unanswered. Shirley is the epitome of the mobile, free young woman of the sixties who has liberated herself from the constraints of family and fiancé and is free to sleep with whomever she pleases; but the real power still lies with the competition judges, men who broker the backstage marketing deals. In this respect the film suggests that sexual liberation does not necessarily liberate women, but this is less a judgement on women's sexual autonomy than a laying bare of the patriarchal codes that shape women's choices. That the film closes with Shirley's younger sister taking to the beauty queen circuit points to a sense of stasis in which a modern and viable feminine identity has yet to be fully imagined.

²⁸ Rachel Moseley, 'Respectability Sewn Up: Dressmaking and Film Star Style in the Fifties and Sixties', *European Journal of Cultural Studies*, 4.4 (2001), 473–90 (p. 480).

²⁹ Beatrice Dawson's costumes are supplemented by evening gowns supplied by Christian Dior of London, ensuring the tastes of female consumers are addressed by outfits that range from the achievable to the aspirational.

³⁰ Moseley, *Growing Up with Audrey Hepburn*, p. 36.

Love without Fear

Wolf Rilla's 1963 film *The World Ten Times Over* shares with *The Beauty Jungle* a central concern with the figure of the single young woman and the opportunities available to her. It is a modestly budgeted black and white film with an X-certificate that Rilla made for the independent Cyclops Productions, with distribution through the British-American Warner-Pathé. During the 1950s Rilla gained a decade of experience working in the British film industry, where he directed both main features and lower-budgeted 'B's, the latter allowing him to take greater risks with his material.³¹ His 1953 film *Marilyn*, for example, portrays a bored young wife married to a dull older man and is modelled on Lana Turner's Cora in *The Postman Always Rings Twice* (1946). While the aspirations of *Marilyn*'s titular heroine are brought to an abrupt end, the film demonstrates Rilla's interest in working with subversive themes in ways that go beyond exploitation. As Steve Chibnall and Brian McFarlane have argued of Rilla's 1950s 'B's, their 'pervasive sense of dissatisfaction with things as they are [...] anticipates the New Wave'.³² These thematic concerns with women's dissatisfaction with their lot find their fullest articulation in Rilla's later film *The World Ten Times Over*.

In this film two young women, Billa (Sylvia Syms) and Ginnie (June Ritchie), share a flat and work as nightclub hostesses. Ginnie is having an affair with Bob (Edward Judd), a wealthy married man who wants to leave his wife for her; Billa has just discovered she is pregnant, the paternity of the baby unknown and unimportant. Events unfold over a single day: Ginnie contemplates a new life with Bob, while Billa endures a visit from her estranged widowed father. Neither man is able to accept the women on their own terms, and, after Ginnie attempts suicide, the women agree that their future lies with each other, a lesbian subtext that was downplayed to meet censorship demands.³³ The film adopts the aesthetic of the *nouvelle vague*, offering a slice of contemporary life captured by a restless camera that roams the streets of London, taking in a range of locations from seedy Soho to the smart new office blocks and hotels shaping the capital's skyline. The cinematographer, Larry Pizer, had worked on Lindsay Anderson's short films in the fifties and brings a documentary impulse to bear on a distinctly unglamorous swinging scene.

³¹ McFarlane, *Encyclopedia of British Film*, p. 567.

³² Steve Chibnall and Brian McFarlane, *The British 'B' Film* (Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan/British Film Institute, 2009), pp. 269–70.

³³ Sylvia Syms recalled, '[a]s far as I was concerned my character was in love with June Ritchie [...] but in those days one could only suggest lesbianism' (quoted in Stephen Bourne, *Brief Encounters: Lesbians and Gays in British Cinema, 1930–1971* (London: Cassell, 1996), p. 181). Syms used a leather coat to make Billa look 'tough' while retaining a 'feminine' edge, and the film opens with Billa gazing wistfully at Ginnie's photograph.

For the trade journal *Kine Weekly* were self-evident, its 'night-club s 'interesting fare for adults', and the notices' during its opening week at th doing 'exceptionally well' during we Syms's reputation as both sexy (*Ice C* and a professional risk-taker (*Victim* older Billa well, while the recent suc of *Loving* suggested associations for Wave forms of social commentary. T lager, a new drink launched in 1962 lager, indicates that producers and ex through the suggestion of sophisticat

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³⁴ *Kine Weekly*, 17 October 1963, p. 9; *Kine*

³⁵ Richard Roud, *Guardian*, 1 November 1 *Cinema*, p. 83.

³⁶ A. S., *Monthly Film Bulletin* (November 1

³⁷ Raymond Durnat, *A Mirror for Engla* (London: Faber, 1970), pp. 204–05.

³⁸ T. Wiseman, *Sunday Express*, 3 November

nes Over shares with *The Beauty Jungle* single young woman and the opportunity for adult, and the film with an independent Cyclops Productions, with can Warner-Pathe. During the 1950s acting in the British film industry, where 'r-budged' Bs, the latter allowing him. His 1953 film *Marilyn*, for example, a dull older man and is modelled on *Always Kings Twice* (1946). While the are brought to an abrupt end, the film with subversive themes in ways that go and Brian McFarlane have argued of dissatisfaction with things as they are thematic concerns with women's dis-articulation in Rilla's later film *The* Rilla (Sylvia Syms) and Ginnie (June tub hostesses. Ginnie is having an affair married man who wants to leave his wife is pregnant, the paternity of the baby old over a single day: Ginnie contem-a endures a visit from her estranged accept the women on their own terms, women agree that their future lies with was downplayed to meet censorship of the *nouvelle vague*, offering a slice of the camera that roams the streets of from seedy Soho to the smart new office skyline. The cinematographer, Larry's short films in the fifties and brings a tly unglamorous swinging scene.

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For the trade journal *Kine Weekly*, the film's 'Points of Appeal' for audiences were self-evident, its 'night-club scenes, sex and attractive stars' offering 'interesting fare for adults; and the film did brisk business, garnering 'good notices' during its opening week at the London Plaza, with admissions noted as doing 'exceptionally well' during weekend trade.³⁴ The casting is astute, with Syms' reputation as both sexy (*Ice Cold in Alex* (1958), *Expresso Bongo* (1959)) and a professional risk-taker (*Victim* (1961)) serving the character of the jaded older Billa well, while the recent success of the younger June Ritchie in *A Kind of Loving* suggested associations for the film between her character and New Wave forms of social commentary. The film's official product tie-up with Harp lager, a new drink launched in 1962 to meet consumer demand for continental lager, indicates that producers and exhibitors hoped to sell the film to audiences through the suggestion of sophisticated taste.

While the film seems to have found a commercial audience, its critical reception was less assured, with mainstream response ranging from outright dismissal to qualified support. Richard Roud for the *Guardian* dismissed it as a real nutcase of a film, while the *Times* critic recoiled from its 'high-toned women's magazine dialogue'.³⁵ *Monthly Film Bulletin* could only compare the film unfavourably with its French progenitors, merely 'imitative of nouvelle vague films [. . .] a glum and modish essay that can only reproduce the surface mannerisms of such films'.³⁶ For the *Bulletin's* auteur critics, Harp lager would be the closest Rilla would get to a continental connection. Raymond Durnat, writing from the perspective of 1970, was kinder in discerning the film's ambiguities when he commented that 'Rilla can't maintain Antonioni's maniacal visual precision [. . .] but it's more than fashion-mongering, it's an honest try' at exploring the new world of modern office blocks and failures of communication between women and men.³⁷ It is perhaps this quality that the *Sunday Express* reviewer had in mind when praising the film for treating 'seriously and sympathetically the kind of girls who are usually the subject of ribald jokes'.³⁸ The varied responses point to how critical readings of the film slip between positioning it as exploitation fare or as serious social commentary, a fairly common reaction for British reviewers when faced with low- or modestly budgeted X-certificate films that could not be contained within the parameters

³⁴ *Kine Weekly*, 17 October 1963, p. 9; *Kine Weekly*, 7 November 1963, p. 10.
³⁵ Richard Roud, *Guardian*, 1 November 1963; *The Times*, cited in Murphy, *Sixties British Cinema*, p. 83.
³⁶ A. S., *Monthly Film Bulletin* (November 1963), p. 156.
³⁷ Raymond Durnat, *A Mirror for England: British Movies from Austerity to Affluence* (London: Faber, 1970), pp. 204-05.
³⁸ T. Wiseman, *Sunday Express*, 3 November 1963.

of 'quality' literary realism.³⁹ Durnat's comment about an 'honest try' points to the challenges facing filmmakers working through the new personal and sexual freedoms and struggling to explore those complexities from a female perspective.

The two women are situated very precisely in an early 1960s London of the popular imagination. Their work as nightclub hostesses, and their string of clients including pillars of 'respectable' society (captains of industry and university professors), has echoes of the Profumo Affair being played out in the British press that year. In a montage sequence, Billa's father trawls the streets of Soho in an attempt to understand the social milieu his daughter inhabits, the hand-held camera jostling through the throng of people who crowd around striptease windows promising 'West-End Jungle Nymphettes!'.⁴⁰ Shop windows display contemporary publications like Eustace Chesser's *Love without Fear*, while carousels of cheap Pan paperbacks promise their readers deliciously salacious stories about 'Sex Kittens'.⁴¹ The options available to the women are played out against this background of the new sexual permissiveness and mass media commercialization of sex. Ginnie is more immediately readable as the free, independent, and mobile young woman quickly becoming the fantasy figure of liberation in the cultural imaginary. Eschewing responsibility and social convention, Ginnie is infuriated by declarations of romantic love ('Why do people have to say they love you just because you go to bed with them?'), and she scorns Billa's attempts to get her to grow up and stop playing around ('Why have I got to make up my mind about anything?'). Ginnie is presented as both free to 'fuck for fun', in Elizabeth Wilson's terms, and equally free to refuse her lover sex on the grounds that 'I don't feel sexy tonight'.⁴² In this respect she is the newly liberated single young woman, freed from the 1950s sexualization of marriage, which placed expectations on wives to be always sexually available to their husbands.⁴³

³⁹ This critical slippage/anxiety connects the film with earlier X-rated films such as *The Flesh is Weak* (1957), which was dismissed by 'quality' critics but nevertheless succeeded in providing some ambiguous depictions of female sexuality that were more innovative than contemporary critics acknowledged. See Melanie Bell, *Femininity in the Frame: Women and 1950s British Popular Cinema* (London: I. B. Tauris, 2010), p. 125.

⁴⁰ The reviewer for *Monthly Film Bulletin* comments that Billa's father (William Hartnell) is made up to look like Lord Attlee in his prime-ministerial days — another nod to the involvement of government ministers in the sex economy (p. 156).

⁴¹ Chesser was part of progressive liberal opinion, which made a case for sex before marriage; his earlier *Getting Married* (1959) had been a best-seller before being withdrawn as a result of hostile reaction from some sections of the press. See Elizabeth Wilson, *Only Halfway to Paradise: Women in Postwar Britain, 1945–1968* (London: Tavistock, 1980) p. 105.

⁴² Wilson, *Only Halfway to Paradise*, p. 108.

⁴³ See Maxine Davis, *The Sexual Responsibility of Woman* (1957), discussed in Cate Haste, *Rules of Desire: Sex in Britain, World War I to the Present* (London: Chatto & Windus, 1992), p. 157.

Despite Ginnie's autonomy, the film's discourse of the sixties offers real declarations for something more, 'I want to suggest a more general dissatisfaction' offers one possible route, but she is a role she has in a power play with his father sketches the options available to a woman with a rudimentary education. Ginnie's observation 'Or I can throw a great big splash' is a tart response to More pointedly, Rilla's screenplay draws actions between men and women enacted place within marriage. Bob's wife Elaine coat and sapphire and diamond jewelry were something my father bought for the nation of Elaine, the suggestion that the sexual economy points to the traps in

The options available to Billa are not pregnancy through the vague suggestion of motivation seems partly driven by her partly by the possibility the child offers. Either way, unmarried motherhood has rebellion, an option that finds its most attempt. No way out is envisaged for the way or another you're caught . . . when engagement with sexual permissiveness a range of opportunities for women are identifies as a 'confusion' about the sex the 1960s: the balance between a criticism with an affirmation of women's right to not find its fullest expression until the 1960s this confusion had yet to be articulated of this uncertainty is perhaps highlighted at a shop display of sexology books. Chesser's title, which promises the heterosexual *Fear*, gives way to a knowing, quiet sexual agency, which goes beyond the Richard Roud's comment about this a wittingly captures some of this uncertainty

⁴⁴ Wilson, *Only Halfway to Paradise*, p. 111.

comment about an 'honest try' points to those complexities from a female

herself in an early 1960s London of the nightclub hostesses, and their string of city (captains of industry and university) Affairs being played out in the scene, Billa's father travels the streets of a social milieu his daughter inhabits, the throng of people who crowd around 'Jungle Nymphettes';⁴⁰ Shop windows promise their readers deliciously salacious options available to the women are new sexual permissiveness and mass is more immediately readable as the woman quickly becoming the fantasy binary. Eschewing responsibility and declarations of romantic love ('Why because you go to bed with them?'), to grow up and stop playing around (but anything?). Ginnie is presented as sons terms, and equally free to refuse feel sexy tonight?⁴² In this respect she is freed from the 1950s sexualization of wives to be always sexually available

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Despite Ginnie's autonomy, the film questions the extent to which the sexual discourse of the sixties offers real freedom to women. Ginnie's frustrated declarations for something more, 'I want out . . . out', have no real focus and suggest a more general dissatisfaction with life. Her rich married lover, Bob, offers one possible route, but she is astute enough to recognize the symbolic role she has in a power play with his family. A meeting with Bob's domineering father sketches the options available to a quick-witted, working-class young woman with a rudimentary education: receptionist or high-class escort. Ginnie's observation 'Or I can throw myself out of the window and make a great big splash' is a tart response to the limited horizons envisaged for her. More pointedly, Rilla's screenplay draws parallels between the economic transactions between men and women enacted in the nightclub and those that take place within marriage. Bob's wife Elaine, sleek and expensively attired in fur coat and sapphire and diamond jewellery, is reduced to a commodity: 'You were something my father bought for me, Bob tells her. Rather than a condemnation of Elaine, the suggestion that wives as well as call girls have a price in the sexual economy points to the traps in which women are caught.

The options available to Billa are no more enticing. She reconciles herself to pregnancy through the vague suggestion that 'it'll be something to have, but her motivation seems partly driven by hostility towards her estranged father and partly by the possibility the child offers to cement her relationship with Ginnie. Either way, unmarried motherhood here functions as an expression of female rebellion, an option that finds its most extreme articulation in Ginnie's suicide attempt. No way out is envisaged for the women. As Billa flatly observes, 'one way or another you're caught . . . whatever you do, you're caught'. The film's engagement with sexual permissiveness and its commentary on the limited range of opportunities for women are consistent with what Elizabeth Wilson identifies as a 'confusion' about the sexual role and representation of women in the 1960s: the balance between a critique of women's 'sexual objectification' with an affirmation of women's right to sexual pleasure on their own terms did not find its fullest expression until the feminist writing of the 1970s.⁴⁴ In the 1960s this confusion had yet to be articulated and worked through, but something of this uncertainty is perhaps hinted at in Billa's expression as she gazes at a shop display of sexology books. Her initial anger and resentment at Chessier's title, which promises the heterosexual married couple *Love without Fear*, gives way to a knowing, quiet smile, in seeming recognition of her own sexual agency, which goes beyond that socially prescribed and normalized. Richard Roud's comment about this as a 'real nutcase of a film' perhaps unwittingly captures some of this uncertainty and confusion about new forms of

⁴⁴ Wilson, *Only Halfway to Paradise*, p. 111.

femininity and female sexuality as they found expression in British culture for the first time.

The Captive Wife

While the two films discussed above deal with the dilemmas facing the single young woman in the early 1960s, *Four in the Morning* is unusual in its focus on the bleakness of married life and motherhood from the woman's perspective, a theme that was rarely found on British cinema screens. Pregnancy, motherhood, and women's role in the home were increasingly discussed in a range of written texts of the decade, including novels, plays, and the liberal press. If the single heroines in the writings of Drabble, Reid Banks, and Delaney negotiated 'the contradictory demands of independence and motherhood', Penelope Mortimer's work dealt with the woman's suffocating dependence on husband and children to give her life meaning.⁴⁵ Mortimer's *Daddy's Gone A-Hunting* (1958) focused on the loneliness of a middle-aged, middle-class mother who derives her only sense of purpose through procuring an abortion for her otherwise independent nineteen-year-old daughter, while *The Pumpkin Eater* (1962) dealt with the depression of a married wife and mother who seemingly 'had it all'. By the early 1960s the *Observer* and the *Guardian* were regularly printing articles about 'desperate housewives', and the National Housewives Register emerged in 1962 to provide support for isolated women.⁴⁶

In many respects this was a continuation of debates that had their roots in the 1950s (and earlier), where the 'impossibility' of the housewife's role came to light when the middle-class woman took on the role with little or no paid support from servants or domestic help. What emerged in the 1960s, however, was an awareness of the sharp incompatibility between the role of housewife and mother and the middle-class woman's belief in her right to autonomy and privacy.⁴⁷ The negative impact of marriage and motherhood on the middle-class woman's professional and social horizons found its most sustained articulation in Betty Friedan's best-selling *The Feminine Mystique* (1963). In Friedan's text the suburban homes of the 'happy housewives' are likened to a 'comfortable concentration camp', populated by women who have 'forfeited their own existence'.⁴⁸ For Friedan, the key issue facing women was a 'problem of identity'

⁴⁵ Philips, *Women's Fiction*, p. 38.

⁴⁶ Dominic Sandbrook, *White Heat: A History of Britain in the Swinging Sixties* (London: Little, Brown, 2006), p. 653.

⁴⁷ See Judy Giles, *The Parlour and the Suburb: Domestic Identities, Class, Femininity and Modernity* (Oxford: Berg, 2004), p. 162. Giles draws on Hannah Gavron's *The Captive Wife* (1966) for this observation. As Giles rightly observes, not all women experienced the role of housewife in this way and some found their voice 'as housewives' (p. 162).

⁴⁸ Betty Friedan, *The Feminine Mystique* (Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1963), pp. 245, 270.

in a culture that did not permit women human beings, a need which is not the idea of a woman's identity being formed, echoed in British publications such as *The Captive Wife* (1966), Drusilla Beyfus's *Fraser's Work* (1968). For the twenty interviewed for Fraser's study, the domestic work was a surprise to her and she was 'humbled' by the idea that her domestic work fit only for fools was beyond her. Beyfus's study spoke of the boring monotony of housework and children go on from day to day, and one never actually finishes.⁵¹ For the study, housework and childcare were compared with paid employment, a 'non-existence' in the role that amounted to nothing.

While sociological studies and novels had little commercial appeal for a mainstream audience, the theme of masculinity. Indeed, more broadly, the themes of work and domesticity are of interest to film scholars. These themes are explored in *Four in the Morning*, the agency of the director and scriptwriter, and the work outside mainstream filmmaking. Italian neorealism, Simmons's creative approach, and poetic realism, and his work was a form of naturalism.⁵³ The budget for the film was small, and the National Film Finance Corporation (NFFC) actors signed up for the working class. Simmons envisaged the film as a commentary on the new relationship between men and women.

⁴⁹ Ibid, p. 68.

⁵⁰ Suzanne Gail, 'The Housewife', in *Work: The Social History of the Working Woman* (Harmondsworth: Penguin/New Left Review, 1971), p. 119.

⁵¹ A twenty-eight-year-old middle-class wife, Drusilla Beyfus, *The English Marriage: Women's Work in the Home* (Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1971), p. 119.

⁵² Hannah Gavron, *The Captive Wife* (Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1968), p. 132.

⁵³ Romance in his search for a 'basic humanism' and 'what you found'; see Josephine Dolan and Andrew Simmons, *Journal of British Cinema and Television Studies* (p. 134). Simmons's preference for poetic realism over the documentarist Larry Pizer.

⁴⁹ Ibid, p. 68.
⁵⁰ Suzanne Gail, 'The Housewife, in Work: Twenty Personal Accounts, ed. by Ronald Fraser (Harmondsworth: Penguin/New Left Review, 1968) pp. 140-55 (p. 141).
⁵¹ A twenty-eight-year-old middle-class wife and mother to two pre-school children cited in Drusilla Beyfus, *The English Marriage: What It Is Like To Be Married Today* (1968; Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1971), p. 119.
⁵² Hannah Gavron, *The Captive Wife: Conflicts of Housebound Mothers* (1966; Harmondsworth: Penguin, 1968), p. 132.
⁵³ Romance in his search for a 'basic humanity' and pragmatic in his commitment to '[shoot] what you found'; see Josephine Dolan and Andrew Spicer, Interview: 'The Outsider: Anthony Simmons, *Journal of British Cinema and Television*, 5.1 (2008), 132-45 (pp. 132-35, quotation on p. 134). Simmons' preference for poetic realism was enhanced by the cinematography of the documentarist Larry Pizer.

the difficulties that we were all experiencing but nobody wanted to talk about'.⁵⁴ An X-certificate film with an extremely limited release, it was a commercial failure, although it did garner prizes on the international film festival circuit. The film is structured around three stories: the dredging of an anonymous young woman's corpse from the Thames; a young wife and mother (Judi Dench) driven to distraction by her crying baby and arguments with her irresponsible husband (Norman Rodway); and a young unmarried woman (Ann Lynn) negotiating a relationship with her uncommitted lover (Brian Phelan). The action takes place across a single night, and the film is edited to suggest that either of the desperate women could be the unidentified body, leaving open the possibility that they have opted for suicide as a solution to their personal problems. As the river police work to identify the body through fingerprinting and clothing, the structure of the narrative extends the question of identity beyond an individual corpse to all women, and the film is thus a sympathetic investigation of femininity.⁵⁵ I want to focus here on the figure of the young wife and mother and show how Simmons juxtaposes a realist mode with stylistic interventions in editing and lighting to suggest the lived reality of motherhood from the woman's perspective.

Jude is the middle-class 'captive wife' of Gavron's study, bewildered by the demands made of her by motherhood and marriage. The family home is a cramped flat comprising three rooms, which Jude struggles to maintain: 'look at this room, what a dreadful mess,' she declares in weary exasperation as she takes in the strew of magazines and jumble of ironing, ironically off-set by an incongruous 'Welcome' sign on the wall. The rooms are grubby and their decoration shabby; there are hair-grease stains on the wallpaper above the bed and dirty fingerprints on the door jambs. The kitchen is fitted with none of the modern labour-saving devices being enthusiastically marketed to young housewives at this time. It is so small that it barely accommodates one person, the lack of physical space augmented by the tight framing and low camera-angle, which positions Jude as engulfed by her surroundings. The *mise en scène* is one of claustrophobic, domestic entrapment, signifying the shrunken horizons of Jude's existence, which is reduced to futile attempts to pacify her fractious, teething baby.

Simmons uses primarily a naturalistic style to shoot the initial scenes of Jude in the flat, employing a static camera and medium-shot framing. Jude's attempts to ignore her child and get some rest in the next room are thwarted by the baby's continual wail, which pierces the thin walls. Jude's patience, worn thin

⁵⁴ Cover note, written by Anthony Simmons, to DVD release of *Four in the Morning*, by Odeon Entertainment, April 2008.

⁵⁵ For a discussion of London locations and the Thames in the film see Charlotte Brunsdon, *London in Cinema* (London: British Film Institute, 2007), pp. 200–01.

through sleep deprivation, finally s her daughter's bedroom and imp shouts 'stop it', and then furiously s the visual register changes. In a turn a medium close-up shows her effect emits a frenzy of squeaking. Such suggests the harm that she might c cot and continues squeezing the toy her from the child's perspective ins side of her face in shadow while the single pearl necklace and the lace fri ling of light and shadow across the bars, mirroring the bars of the child in an oppressive domestic space. In fied, angry at the child, at herself, an is startlingly frank, emotionally raw, camerawork, and direction working mother. This emotional rawness u *Daily Telegraph's* reviewer was read baby' and the absent 'boozy husband *Woman's Own*', but confessed himse material into the 'realistic and most of broadsheet critics was mixed, wit discomforting [...] but distinguished the film's treatment of its subject ma

This scene also provides a conte Jude's later interactions with her morning with the friend with whom in a prolonged scene where Simmo relationship between the sexes' is p space is given over to Jude's expre Friedan's observation of middle-class their increasing self-awareness of th husband's needs ('we have this type o it suits you'), and she envies his fre these four walls'). She resents that his you think you can just come and go a

⁵⁶ Patrick Grubbs, *Daily Telegraph*, 17 Dec

⁵⁷ Dilys Powell, *Sunday Times*, 19 Decemb ground discussing the film's photography.

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through sleep deprivation, finally snaps: in anger and frustration she re-enters her daughter's bedroom and impatiently rattles the bars of the child's cot, shouts 'stop it, and then furiously squeezes the child's squeaky toy rabbit. Here the visual register changes. In a turn away from the cot and towards the camera, a medium close-up shows her effectively wringing the toy rabbit's neck, which emits a frenzy of squeaking. Such displaced activity for her own frustrations suggests the harm that she might do to her child. She turns back towards the cot and continues squeezing the toy. The camera cuts to a low-angle close-up of her face in shadow while the other is brightly lit, light reflecting off her single pearl necklace and the lace frill of her nightie. The expressionistic model-ling of light and shadow across the curtains in the background evokes prison bars, mirroring the bars of the child's cot and suggesting how both are trapped in an oppressive domestic space. In this scene Jude is both terrifying and terrified, angry at the child, at herself, and at her husband for his absence. The scene is startlingly frank, emotionally raw, and disturbing to watch, the performance, camerawork, and direction working to express how Jude feels as a wife and mother. This emotional rawness unsettled some contemporary critics. The *Daily Telegraph's* reviewer was ready to dismiss the scenario of the 'teething baby' and the absent 'boozy husband' as pure melodrama, akin to 'a letter to *Woman's Own*', but confessed himself moved by the director's expansion of the material into the 'realistic and most painful scenes imaginable'.⁵⁶ The response of broadsheet critics was mixed, with Dilys Powell's description of it as 'pretty discomforting [...] but distinguished, pointing to how unnerved many were by the film's treatment of its subject matter'.⁵⁷

This scene also provides a contextual frame for the viewer to understand Jude's later interactions with her husband. Returning home early in the morning with the friend with whom he has been drinking, the action unfolds in a prolonged scene where Simmons's thematic preoccupation with the 'new relationship between the sexes' is played out in full. Considerable narrative space is given over to Jude's expression of her reality, which chimes with Friedan's observation of middle-class women forfeiting their own existence and their increasing self-awareness of this. For Jude, life is structured around her husband's needs ('we have this type of row, at this time in the morning, because it suits you'), and she envies his freedom and autonomy ('you can get out of these four walls'). She resents that his freedom is based on her exploitation ('Do you think you can just come and go as you please because I'm here, what choice

⁵⁶ Patrick Grubbs, *Daily Telegraph*, 17 December 1965.
⁵⁷ Dilys Powell, *Sunday Times*, 19 December 1965. Powell, like many other critics, was on safer ground discussing the film's photography.

do I have?'), and she is stifled by her lack of achievement in anything she considers meaningful ('Do you know what happened to me today? I just got one day older'). This sense of non-existence and 'standing still' is consistent with the views expressed by Hannah Gavron's respondents. By referring to herself in the third person — 'Jude'll wash the cups in the morning' — she separates the housewife from other aspects of her identity, which she also attempts to maintain through paid work done at home. Her husband derisively dismisses her efforts — 'she's so clever . . . market research and all. Earns her own pocket money then blames me when she's tired in the morning' — and tosses aside her work papers. Jude's response, 'Put that down', is delivered with quiet but forceful conviction and suggests how she hangs on to paid work as one of the few reminders of an autonomous self.

The film offers no resolution for Jude. She briefly abandons the baby in the flat to demonstrate to her husband how she feels, but returns because, as she puts it simply, 'there was nowhere else to go'. Like Billa and Ginnie she is 'caught'. This sense of imprisonment and the need for an escape route spoke directly to women, like the film critic Nina Hibbin, who found Jude's 'final gesture of resignation [. . .] the most genuinely distressing statement of the established status of wifehood that I've seen on screen.'⁵⁸ While Deborah Philips finds in the work of Drabble and Reid Banks 'independent heroines who cope' with motherhood, Simmons presents an altogether bleaker view and articulates the emotional cost borne by women in their coping.⁵⁹

Conclusion

These films, which range across popular taste and art-house fare, demonstrate how certain filmmakers questioned the dominant image of the mobile, free young woman empowered through sexual liberation, and negotiated spaces in the cultural fabric to address their audiences with figurations that suggested some of the aspirations for, and anxieties about, contemporary femininities. Setting these texts alongside the canon of sixties women's fiction adds a further dimension to the well-known picture of a culture becoming increasingly self-conscious about femininity, as observed in the studies of Elizabeth Wilson, Deborah Philips, and others. It would be stretching the point too far to claim Guest, Rilla, and Simmons as feminist filmmakers. The careers of Guest and Rilla petered out by the seventies, Simmons's output was small, and they never again produced such complex representations of women. Nevertheless, it is in these male-authored, women-centred texts that some of the most pointed critiques of women's roles and sexual politics are to be found in the film culture of the period.

⁵⁸ Nina Hibbin, *Daily Worker*, 18 December 1965.

⁵⁹ Philips, *Women's Fiction*, p. 46.

Already Seen? Look and Postmodern

ALICE

Liverpool John M

J.P. Let me explain if I can penetrate the mind of my friend Teddy is *not déjàvu*, as you, and a Very simply because he is *not* something taken place and most certainly not privy

First performed on 8 May 1992, J suggested, 'might be thought of as Lo matory intervention into the intense *Anger*, the totemic play of 1950s Brit discourse has run, brought about a Br *Anger* initiated the overthrow of a privileged London moguls, and the n working class into a new mode of pla radicalism of the 1960s. From its oper that of its sequel, Osborne's first pl commentators some response to the i times.

Déjàvu, as a sequel produced more means of focusing changing respons relation to its author and to the wider the angry middle-aged Jimmy Porter p. 300) is rife with ambiguous prioritie rhetorical mode, J.P. (as his character friend Cliff for his peasantry, in this ca meaning of 'déjàvu' and its now ubiq

¹ John Osborne, *Déjàvu*, in *John Osborne: Pla* (p. 280); *Look Back in Anger*, in *ibid.*, pp. 1–95 numbers, preceded (where necessary) by the a parentheses in the text.)